Sydney Travel Guide

Harbour icons, golden beaches and outdoor living - Australia

Sydney: Overview and History

Sydney is the largest city in Australia and the capital of the state of New South Wales. For tens of thousands of years the area has been home to Aboriginal people; the Gadigal people of the Eora Nation are the traditional custodians of the land around Sydney Harbour.

In 1788 the British First Fleet, led by Captain Arthur Phillip, arrived from England and set up a penal colony. The settlement grew into a major port and, like Singapore, kept strong ties with London and the British Empire.

Sydney hosted the Summer Olympic Games in 2000. Today it is a multicultural city known for its beautiful harbour, beaches and relaxed outdoor lifestyle.

Because Sydney is in the Southern Hemisphere, its seasons are the opposite of Europe's: summer is from December to February and winter from June to August.

Sydney: Top Attractions

The Sydney Opera House is one of the most famous buildings of the twentieth century. It was designed by the Danish architect Jorn Utzon, opened in 1973 and became a UNESCO World Heritage Site in 2007. Its white roof shells look like sails on the harbour. Guided tours and performances are available every day.

The Sydney Harbour Bridge, nicknamed the Coathanger, opened in 1932. You can walk across it for free, or join BridgeClimb to climb to the top of its arch. Every New Year's Eve the bridge is the centre of a spectacular fireworks show.

Bondi Beach is Australia's most famous beach. The Bondi to Coogee coastal walk is about 6 kilometres long and passes cliffs, ocean pools and smaller beaches. A ferry from Circular Quay to Manly is a cheap way to enjoy harbour views.

The Royal Botanic Garden sits next to the Opera House, and Taronga Zoo, reached by ferry, has Australian animals such as koalas and kangaroos with views of the city skyline.

Sydney: Neighborhoods and Food

The Rocks is Sydney's oldest neighbourhood, with sandstone buildings, historic pubs and a weekend market, right next to the Harbour Bridge. Darling Harbour and Barangaroo are waterfront areas with restaurants, museums and the SEA LIFE aquarium.

Surry Hills and Newtown are creative inner-city suburbs with cafes, bars and vintage shops, while Paddington is known for its terrace houses and boutiques. Manly is a relaxed beach suburb.

Sydney has a world-class cafe culture. Order a flat white coffee and a smashed avocado on toast for brunch. Seafood is excellent: try Sydney rock oysters, barramundi, and fish and chips by the beach. The Sydney Fish Market is one of the largest in the Southern Hemisphere.

Classic Australian treats include the meat pie, the pavlova meringue dessert, lamingtons and Tim Tam biscuits. Thanks to immigration, Sydney also has great Thai, Vietnamese, Chinese and Lebanese food.

Sydney: Getting Around and Practical Tips

Sydney's public transport includes trains, buses, light rail, the new driverless Metro and the much loved harbour ferries from Circular Quay. Pay with an Opal card or tap on with a contactless bank card; there are daily and weekly fare caps.

Sydney Airport (SYD) is close to the city. The Airport Link train reaches Central station in about 13 minutes. Emirates flies non-stop between Sydney and Dubai in about 14 hours, and Qantas and Singapore Airlines connect Sydney with London via Singapore or other stopovers.

The currency is the Australian dollar (AUD). Tipping is not expected but is appreciated for good service. The Australian sun is very strong, so always wear sunscreen and swim between the red and yellow flags on patrolled beaches.

The best times to visit Sydney are spring, September to November, and autumn, March to May, when the weather is warm but not too hot. The Vivid Sydney festival of light takes place in May and June, and New Year's Eve fireworks draw huge crowds.

Sydney: Sample Itinerary and Day Trips

Day 1: Tour the Sydney Opera House, stroll through the Royal Botanic Garden to Mrs Macquarie's Chair, then explore The Rocks and walk across the Harbour Bridge. Day 2: Spend the day at Bondi Beach and do the Bondi to Coogee coastal walk.

Day 3: Take the ferry to Taronga Zoo in the morning and the ferry to Manly in the afternoon, then have dinner in Surry Hills or Newtown.

The Blue Mountains are about two hours west by train. At Katoomba you can see the famous Three Sisters rock formation and walk through eucalyptus forest. The Hunter Valley is Australia's oldest wine region, and the Royal National Park, south of the city, has cliffs, beaches and walking trails.

Long-haul travellers often break the journey to Sydney with a stopover in Dubai or Singapore.